



Big Fish Energy

US – Northeast/NYC

The Premise

If 2026 was about becoming the protagonist of your own hero's journey, then 2027 is about choosing where that story plays out.

Scale has flattened culture. Federal systems feel distant. People are turning inward, investing in small ponds where their voice, taste, and presence actually register.

Big Fish Energy is the shift toward being deeply known in a finite community over being broadly visible to none.

In 2027, mattering somewhere specific beats being seen everywhere.

Why is this important?

People are exhausted by systems that optimize everything while making life feel less stable, less personal, less grounding. AI has compressed discovery into instant gratification, and the byproduct is a culture where everything feels replicable, nothing feels earned, and personal taste has been quietly automated. Federal trust is eroding in ways New Yorkers feel daily. [ICE has arrested more than 9,600 people in the city since January 2025, most without criminal records.](#) The 43-day government shutdown, the longest in US history, [drove flight delays up 467% at New York airports and cost the travel sector \\$6.1 billion.](#) Spirit Airlines collapsed in May 2026, the first major US airline to fold in 25 years. The Trump travel ban expanded from 19 countries to 75 in seven months. [Publications labeled the pattern "travel nightmare,"](#) but staying close became more than logistics. It's an era of yearning — for the past, for physical spaces, for shared experiences that can't be automated. The 2016 revival is everywhere. Analog is emotional infrastructure: listening bars, sober-curious clubs, literary readings pulling rooms across the city. Culture is how people find each other again. Duck libraries appear on Chelsea sidewalks. NYC dating moves from apps to IRL singles events. Concerts turn into immersive worlds — Charli XCX's Brat, Beyoncé's Cowboy Carter, Shrek raves — rituals that only exist if you show up. When the systems above feel unreliable, people don't disengage. They reinvest locally. The smaller the pond, the more meaningful it is to matter in it.

What is the core conflict / opportunity?

The systems today reward scale, but consumers are increasingly craving intimacy, familiarity, and local recognition. That's the tension.

AI, algorithms, and centralized media push culture toward speed and replication. Mass visibility is the default. At the same time, political instability and institutional distrust make people feel detached from the systems running their lives. The result is more visibility, less meaning.

Both ends of the spectrum have real trade-offs. Scale lowers prices and expands access. Local networks can be gatekept, insular, and exclusionary by design. Neither is purely good or bad.

What's clear is where the momentum is heading. People are opting into smaller ecosystems where participation, reputation, and presence carry more weight than broad online attention. Big Fish Energy lives in that opt-in.

Key statistics / quotes / evidence (from within your country)

Collapse of Federal Trust

- [ICE agents deployed at TSA checkpoints](#)
- [landlords weaponizing immigration threats](#)
- [delivery cyclists rising crash rates](#)
- [workers threatening strikes](#)
- [LaGuardia plane crash](#)

Zohran Mamdani Effect

- [age played a big role in the NYC mayoral election](#)
- [how design helped Zohran win](#)
- [office of mass engagement](#)
- [YA's drift toward socialism](#)

NYC Community Rebuilding

- [tenants vs. landlords](#)
- [new yorkers get paid \\$30/hr to clear snow](#)
- [New Yorkers building snowmen in parks](#)
- [homeownership paths for gig workers](#)

Era of Yearning

- [2016 revival trend](#)
- [yearning slang](#)
- [duck libraries](#)
- [indie sleeze](#)
- [rise of humanities](#)
- [listening bars](#)

Human vs. Machine

- [Friend AI protest](#)
- [NYC scraps new AI high school](#)
- [GLP1 changing consumer behaviors](#)
- [Accenture AI anxiety](#)

Why did the studio pick this one?

This shift changes how consumers build trust and cultural loyalty. People are becoming more sensitive to experiences that feel generic, mass-produced, or emotionally disconnected from real life.

The future of AI is collaborative, not replacement-driven. The real opportunity is that technology can compress the work so people have more time to build relationships, create culture, and participate in their communities.

Our job as designers is to be AI interpreters. We build the infrastructure and norms that help people use AI intuitively, without the anxiety that their output is slop.

Brands that understand local behavior, emotional needs, and cultural nuance will feel more trustworthy than brands that only optimize for scale and efficiency. The companies that win will make people feel connected, involved, and recognized, not just targeted.

In your roles within Song and DDP, how does it impact your work or your clients?

Universal aesthetics no longer guarantee relevance. Consumers want experiences that feel specific, intentional, and rooted in real communities. The strongest brands will feel less like distant corporations and more like ecosystems people genuinely want to belong to.

For designers:

- **Premium on taste:** AI makes technical execution easy. Taste is now the differentiator. Designers who cultivate and defend a clear point of view will lead the next era.
- **Era of yearning:** Across generations, people are looking backward — older ones nostalgic for a moment before everything got optimized, younger ones anemoic for a past they never lived. Both want design that feels made by someone for someone. Visible craft, imperfection, specificity, and warmth answer a real emotional need.
- **AI for good:** The question is no longer whether to use AI, but how. The opportunity is not to flood the global pond with more noise. It's to use AI to strengthen smaller, trust-rich communities.

For clients

- **Redefining legitimacy:** The companies gaining real traction aren't the ones with the biggest reach. They're the ones embedded in real communities. Local partnerships, cultural participation, and consistent presence matter more than mass reach.
- **Community building as strategy:** This is a trust strategy, not a marketing ploy. Brands that give people a meaningful role build deeper loyalty than brands still optimizing only for scale.